

Cristina Zenato

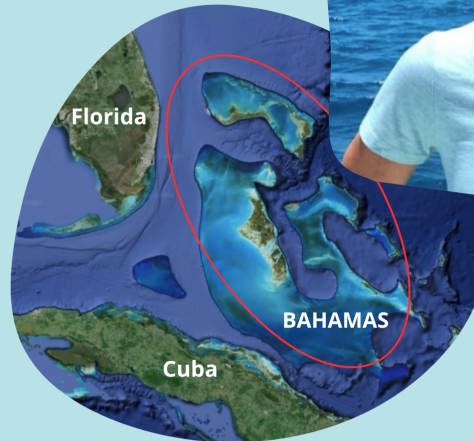
Shark behaviorist

Diving instructor

Cave diver

Contact:

✉ cristinazenato.com
☎ +12427270896
✉ czenato@gmail.com
📷 cristinazenato



Her life

Childhood: born in Ital and raised in the Africal tropical forest in the Congo (Zaire)

Studies: studied **languages** through history and literature

- During her holidays in the Bahamas, she got a job as an **interpreter** at a hotel
- At the same time, she completed her **diving** certifications
- She fell in love with **sharks** and **caves**, extended her stay, and became a **professional diver** and **diving instructor**

Sharks

Cristina has always been curious about **sharks**, and it was in the Bahamas that she encountered one for the first time. Fascinated by these animals, which she describes as **shy**, she has applied her knowledge to develop protocols for diving with them safely.

When diving with sharks, she adapts her **behavior** depending on the species in order to **share** their environment peacefully.

She has now been diving with sharks for 28 years and has gained experience with twelve different species.

"There's no monsters in the sea, only the ones you make up in your head."

A typical day with Cristina

Cristina starts her day around 4:30–5:00 AM. She enjoys the quiet of her home to take some time for herself: reading a **book**, doing a **puzzle**, or checking her **social media**.

Her workday begins at 6:00 AM. She manages a wide range of tasks, including taking **calls**—sometimes with **news** outlets such as CNN—handling **emails**, attending to **administrative duties**, and occasionally visiting **schools**.

After completing these tasks, she dedicates herself to the other part of her work: **diving**. Depending on her clients, she either dives in **caves** or with **sharks**. As a result, she spends the majority of her workday in the water. It is a very demanding job, both physically and mentally.

Caves

She discovered caves during her eleventh dive. She describes them as a **world unlike any** on this planet:

'A cave tells you its past, its present, and even its future.'

For her, caves have their own sense of time, which flows much more slowly than ours. While climate change has greatly impacted coral reefs, it does not yet seem to have reached underwater caves.

"Caves are the most out of sight, out of mind place. It's a peaceful place."

Ecology

She uses her profession to **educate** the public about sharks. She works for shark **conservation** worldwide through her dives and **public talks**.

She especially works with **Caribbean reef sharks**, most of which recognize her. She also uses this relationship to safely remove **hooks** from their jaws.

Cristina launched a **petition** and campaign, supported by the Bahamas National Trust and the PEW organization, to have the Bahamas declared a shark **sanctuary**.

"Voice for the voiceless."



Cristina and her husband have also taken up the rescue of **stray dogs**, particularly **pit bulls**. They have adopted three: Tino, Mack, and Blue.

30-year career – 21,000 dives to her credit